2026 IFI Fatherhood Essay Contest

Deadline: March 19

Student's Name / Nombre del Estudiante Abigail Castaneda

Grade / Grado 10th

Father/Father-Figure Name / Nombre del Padre/Figura Paterna AntonioCastaneda

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Writing About / Escribiendo Sobre:

- (●) Father / Padre
- ( ) Grandfather / Abuelo
- ( ) Stepdad / Padrasto
- ( ) Father-Figure / Figura Paterna

"What my father or an important father-figure* means to me"

"Lo que mi padre o una figura paterna importante* significa para mí"

My dad isn' t the best person at explaining how he feels, yet I know that doesn't mean he doesn't care. He is one of the most prominent figures in my life that taught me how to love. He taught me how to overcome issues that come my way because that's life. When something bad happens no matter what you have to keep moving forward. At times it might seem like everyone around you is moving forward and leaving you behind but he taught me that when you feel that way is the time when you work even harder to catch up.He has helped me through so many things which he is unaware of. My dad has worked unbelievably hard his entire life for me,my sister, my mom himself, the people around him and the rest of my family.These things led me to believe he is the most selfless person I have ever met in my life.

My dad was born in Mexico or more specifically in Ocotlan, Jalisco. He had 12 siblings along with his mother and father. My dad grew up very poor and had to share everything and by the age of 10 he was working in a bakery as a delivery boy to help support his family. One thing I realized through my life is how appreciative my dad is of the small things he gets. Most things he would appreciate is what people along with myself generally view as an everyday thing. When I asked him why he has so much appreciation for small things he explained that when he was younger he would see something as small as soda and chips as a major treat. A few months ago I brought home a bag of Lays potato chips from school and I asked him if he wanted them, he immediately took them and ate them quickly and I messed with him and said "wow you really like these chips?". He told me a story of when he and his brother Ricardo were younger, one of their more wealthy uncles, invited them to help out at a country club and they would get paid. They agreed because it was easy money, they worked for about 3 hours helping serve and they were paid a bit of money, yet along with the money they got a bottle of soda and a bag of lays chips. My dad and his brother were in shock that they got soda and chips and were beyond appreciative and my dad said it was one of the best things he ever tasted. For that reason it became his favorite kind of chip and everytime he has a bag it takes him back to that day.

All his life my dad has had to work for what he has and has never had an easy way out. Not only this but he constantly put others before himself. He has helped me and my family in every possible way, shape, and form. I believe the best part of all he does is how little he notices he's doing something nice. He just does, he doesn't expect in return. If you are a genuine person you don't expect things in return for being a good person, you are just good.He has taught me that nothing ever comes for free

3000 Character Maximum / Máximo de Caracteres

Father/Grandfather/Step-Dad/Father-Figure reaction to this essay:

Reacción de padre/abuelo/padrastro/figura paterna a este ensayo:

He was extrmely overjoyed that I feel this way about him.

2000 Character Maximum / Máximo de Caracteres

** Father-Figure can be a stepdad, grandfather, uncle, pastor/rabbi/shaman, God, or an ideal vision of a father.*

**Una figura paterna puede ser un padrastro, un abuelo, un tío, un pastor/rabino/chamán, Dios, o un visión ideal de un padre.*

CONTEST DETAILS

Each student is asked to write a 3000 character (or less) essay on the theme “What My Father or an Important Father-Figure Means to Me,” describing their relationship with their father or father-figure. Students should share their true feelings. Provide examples of joys, frustrations or special memories they have as well as commenting about what they would most like to see in their relationship. A father-figure can be a stepdad, grandfather, uncle, coach, pastor/rabbi/shaman, God, or an ideal vision of a father.

CRITERIA FOR ESSAY JUDGING

Submissions will be evaluated according to grade level. Judging criteria will consist of:

1. How the essay describes the relationship.
2. Detail and stories that demonstrate the character of the father/father-figure.
3. Honesty, clarity, simplicity of writing.
4. Overall grade level appropriate writing skill.

JUDGING PROCESS

1. Essays will be divided into the 13 grade levels (K-12).
2. Volunteers will use the above judging criteria, reading every essay. Top essays from the first round will be sent to a final essay reading session.
3. At the final essay reading, volunteers will then select 10 essays per grade. Up to 130 essay semi-finalists will receive special recognition.
4. The top 13 essay writers will be invited to the IFI Fatherhood Dinner Celebration.
5. All entrants will receive a Certificate of Participation.

RULES

1. One entry per person.
2. All essays must be original, unaided by AI and created by the student.
3. All entries become the property of Illinois Fatherhood Initiative (IFI). IFI will not be able to return them.
4. Entry into the contest transfers copyright of the essay to IFI and grants IFI permission to reproduce without compensation all or any portion of the essay and response on an unlimited, world-wide basis in its publications and media channels.
5. When appropriate and with parent/guardian permission, IFI will cite the name of the author(s) if significant portions of a positive essay/response are used. IFI will also change or conceal names to maintain confidentiality if requested.
6. Contest is open to Illinois students (K-12).
7. Deadline for upload or postmark is March 19th.
8. Completed forms can be uploaded on 4dads.org or mailed to:

   1515 S. Grove Avenue, #3667, Barrington, IL 60011.